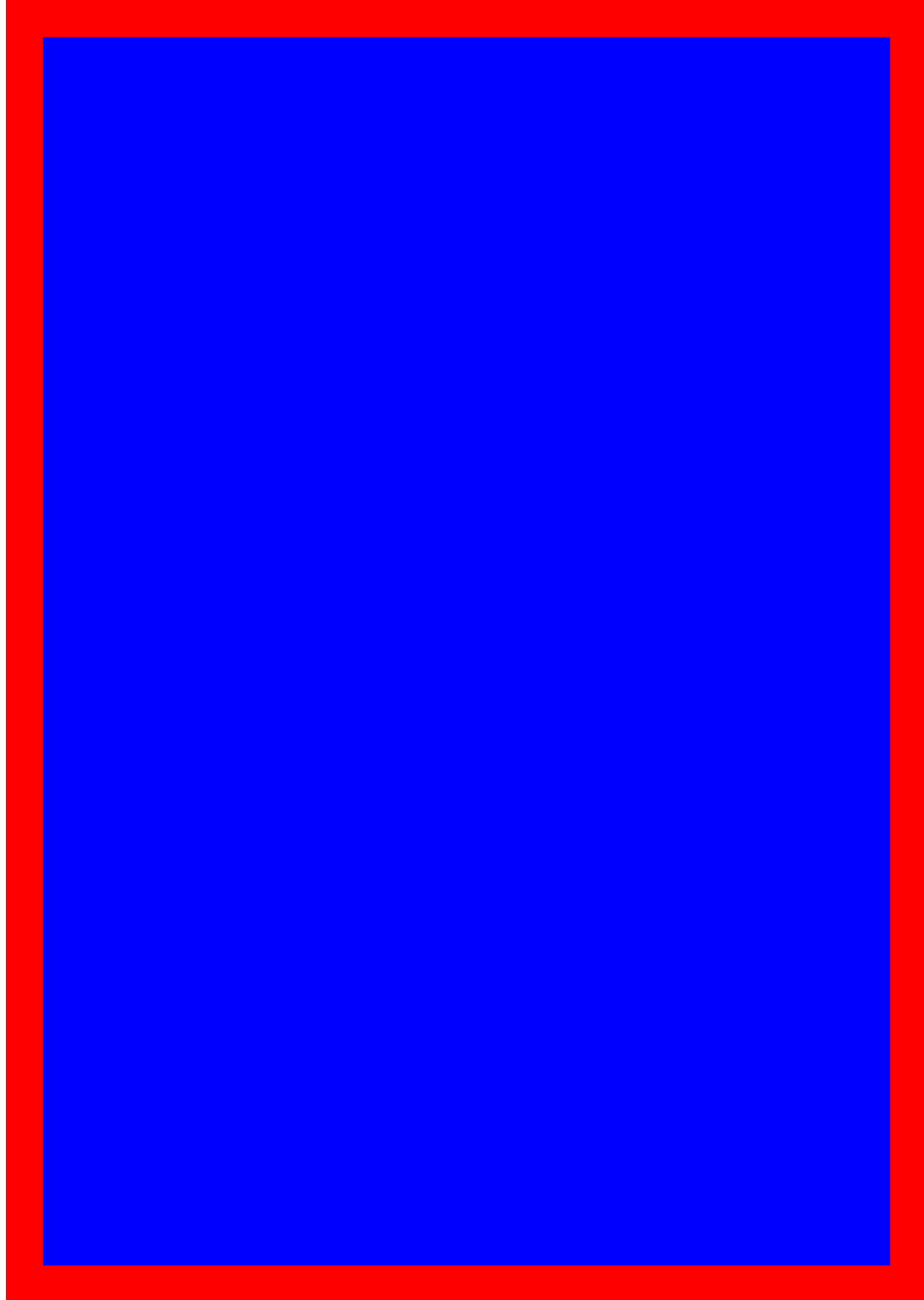




the 1990s, the number of people in the UK who are employed in the public sector has increased by 1.5 million (from 2.5 million in 1980 to 4 million in 1998) and the number of people in the public sector who are employed in health care has increased by 1.2 million (from 1.3 million in 1980 to 2.5 million in 1998) (Department of Health 1999).

There is a growing emphasis on the need to improve the quality of care provided in the public sector. This has led to a number of initiatives, including the introduction of the National Patient Safety Agency (NPSA) in 1999, the establishment of the National Institute for Clinical Excellence (NICE) in 2001, and the introduction of the Health Care Act 2001. These initiatives have all aimed to improve the quality of care provided in the public sector, and to ensure that patients are safe and that the quality of care is high.

One of the key areas of focus for these initiatives has been the issue of patient safety. This has led to a number of initiatives, including the introduction of the National Patient Safety Agency (NPSA) in 1999, the establishment of the National Institute for Clinical Excellence (NICE) in 2001, and the introduction of the Health Care Act 2001. These initiatives have all aimed to improve the quality of care provided in the public sector, and to ensure that patients are safe and that the quality of care is high.

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